

PCaP Newsletter

In This Issue

Greetings from Dr. James Mohler	1
Your Next Follow-up Call	1
Flashback	1
Living with Prostate Cancer	2
What We have Learned from You	2
Surviving Cancer	3
PCaP Staff	4

Flashback-1939

The average age of PCaP participants at the time of their cancer diagnosis was 65 years old. What was life like when they were born? What was popular?



Movies:
"Gone with the Wind"
and "The Wizard of Oz"

Songs: "Over the Rainbow" - Judy Garland,
"God Bless America" - Kate Smith



What did things cost?

Car: \$750

House: \$6,400

Gas: 19 cents per gallon

Postage stamps: 3 cents

Bread: 8 cents per loaf

Milk: 49 cents per gallon



Dear PCaP Participants,

From all of us at PCaP, THANK YOU! Words are insufficient to express our gratitude for your participation in PCaP. Many people were skeptical that we could accomplish such a study, but WE overcame all these hurdles thanks to you! You can be proud to say that you are a member of one of the largest studies of prostate cancer ever undertaken.

PCaP was started in order to learn why prostate cancer can be so different among men, growing faster in some and slower in others. We also are looking at quality of life and treatment of men who have had prostate cancer. The Department of Defense originally gave us \$15 million to fund PCaP, and the American Cancer Society continues to fund PCaP follow-up. PCaP research will result in many publications over the next decade, and we will continue to update our public website with these publications. Your participation, the stories you tell us, and the information you provide to us are so important; PCaP would not be possible without your willingness, enthusiasm, and dedication to our efforts to understand the causes of prostate cancer and how to prevent it.

We hope that you will continue to participate in PCaP. We want to stay in touch with you and hear about your experiences as prostate cancer survivors. Please rest assured that we will learn much from you and that men who develop prostate cancer in the future will benefit greatly.

Sincerely yours,

Dr. James Mohler, PCaP Co-Director
And everyone with PCaP!



Your Next Follow-up Call

We have finished our second year of follow-up and are now calling people for the third year. This third phone call will be similar to the second in many ways. We'll ask about your doctor visits and treatments. We also will ask you to sign new medical records release forms so that we may get your most recent medical records from your doctors. We'll also ask you to complete a survey by mail or over the phone and will ask questions about your quality of life and any health problems you may have been having lately.

Living with Prostate Cancer

As you all know, living with the symptoms of prostate cancer and the side effects of its various treatments can be difficult. But there are some things that you can do to make life a bit easier. Taking steps to manage your treatment side effects, easing stress, eating healthy, and getting regular exercise, are all things that can potentially improve your quality of life as a prostate cancer survivor. Here are some tips that might help:



- To minimize the symptoms of incontinence, try to decrease your intake of fluids that contain caffeine and alcohol, if not avoid them all together. That said, it is important to keep hydrated, so still try to drink plenty of water, milk, and juices.
- Try to empty your bladder before you go to bed, this will hopefully decrease the number of times that you wake up during the night with the urge to urinate. Also try to urinate before doing anything strenuous, like lifting a table or working out; this will decrease the chance of leaking urine during these activities.
- Bowel issues are another common side effect of some prostate cancer treatments. Talking to your doctor about these issues is important, and they might recommend taking an over-the-counter medication to relieve some of these problems.
- Having cancer is a stressful time for almost all patients. But learning how to decrease the amount of stress one has can go a long way towards improving quality of life. Some ways of decreasing stress are getting a good amount of rest and eating healthy, well balanced meals.
- Sticking to a healthy diet isn't just important because it relieves stress; it can also help you recover faster and keep some side effects from getting worse. Make sure that you are getting the right number of calories and protein in your diet.
- Talk to your doctor to see if you are healthy enough to exercise. Getting regular exercise can help you stay active and feel less worn down.

What We have Learned from You

After you were diagnosed with prostate cancer, all of you had to decide what to do about it. Do I want to have treatment, or not? What kind of treatment should I get? We know there isn't one perfect treatment to cure prostate cancer yet, but we didn't know why some men are happy with the treatment they get and others are not. Here's what we learned:



- Men who felt their doctors told them the whole story about side effects felt good about their treatment choice.
- Men who felt that they have all the information needed to make a treatment decision felt good about that decision.
- Men who felt that they have a good relationship with their doctor, meaning they were happy with the time their doctor spends with them and their doctor's patience, friendliness, concern and respect for them felt good about their treatment choice.
- Men who felt that their prostate cancer treatment had not affected their relationship with their spouse felt good about their treatment choice.

Surviving Cancer

Many cancer patients describe diagnosis, treatment and survivorship as a journey - sometimes one that comes with confusing maps and directions or without signposts and guidebooks. Our research shows the importance of having information available to make decisions and having support through family, friends and doctors during this difficult journey. For many survivors, the end of treatment can be a time of mixed emotions- a time for celebration, yet also a time of more challenges. Feeling unsure as to what comes next and feeling lost about moving forward are common feelings, and many questions may surface —

- What do I do now?
- How can I stay healthy?
- Will my cancer come back?
- What about the side effects of treatment?
- How do I get back to "normal"? Is there a new "normal"?

In addition, though many survivors feel well, others can experience lingering health issues, financial consequences, and social concerns. It is important for you to know there are tools available to help you move beyond the illness and positively impact the quality of your life. It is also important to take care of yourself, to make follow-up appointments with your health care provider and make sure you let them know of any physical or emotional things that may be bothering you, including things that get in the way of your daily life and well-being. Survivorship programs and clinics can help you and your family address these concerns and help you feel better-in body and mind.

Survivorship care plans and survivorship clinic visits are tools to help create an easier transition to life after cancer for both you and your doctor. They will help you:

- Address any physical and emotional concerns you have following cancer treatment
- Understand the treatment you received and its potential side effects
- Obtain recommendations for follow-up care, such as check-ups with your doctor, tests, and what to expect
- Develop a personalized action plan for healthy living
- Get other referrals as needed, for example: symptom management or medication clinics, nutrition consult, etc.
- Transition back to your community health care provider by providing a concise summary of your cancer treatment and a survivorship care plan for you and your primary care provider.



Remember that you are not alone! There are peer support groups that connect those touched by cancer with another person whose experiences with cancer are similar. Your doctor can provide valuable resources on things like nutrition and physical activity recommendations, as well as help you manage any side effects you may experience after treatment. Keeping communication channels open with your doctor, family, and friends will help you feel good as a prostate cancer survivor!

PCaP Staff

Katie's story

I have been a nurse for the past 10 years. I started my nursing career working in the hospital setting and traveling around the United States working with heart patients.

When I moved to North Carolina I was looking for a change. I came to work for PCaP in 2005 and I was one of the original nurses who came to your home after you were diagnosed with prostate cancer. Now in this 3 year follow-up study, I am who you talk with on the phone.

Since I've started working for PCaP I have had two boys, now 1 and 3 years old. Part of me would love to stay home with them, but the other part of me feels so vested in this study. Over the years I have heard about your lives and how you have dealt with prostate cancer and the effects it has had on you and your loved ones and I want to be a part of this study's success. I have learned so much about the process of research and how much effort it takes from both study participants and researchers to get worthwhile information. This study has opened my eyes to the reality of prostate cancer and made me realize how important it is to find out as much as we can.

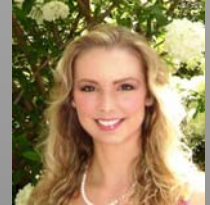
A Special Thanks!

I just want to tell all the men in this study how incredibly proud I am that you have stuck with us. I know it's been hard for some of you to stay committed to PCaP for so many years. However, because you have given us information from the beginning, you are especially important for the future of prostate cancer. I hope that you will continue to be involved in our future studies, because sharing information about your lives is extremely valuable.

Katie Nimmer



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PCaP Co-Director
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